

FAMILY AFFAIR (from left) Jameel Khan, Geetanjali Kulkarni, Harsh Mayar and Vaibhav Raj Gupta in *Gullak*

GULLAK harks back to the good old days of 1980s Doordarshan dramas when shows like *Yeh Jo Hai Zindagi* and *Nukkad* won over audiences with their 'simplicity'

in the very next, you are moved. Singh hails from eastern Uttar Pradesh and has studied at Allahabad University. His list of influences is diverse—the literature of O. Henry, Premchand and Swadesh Deepak on the one hand and the films of Abbas Kiarostami, Wong Kar Wai, Fatih Akin and Asghar Farhadi on the other.

Actor Jameel Khan, who plays the show's principled patriarch Santosh Mishra, is in awe of Singh's craft. "Durgesh is being humble. If it was only about observing life, we would have had many *Gullaks* by now. He has tremendous insight into emotions and anecdotes and his choice of words. The satire in his one-liners is awesome. Even the commentary (*Gullak's* narration) has so much depth." For Geetanjali Kulkarni, whose Instagram is inundated with messages referring to her by her role as "Annu ki Mummy", the show harks back to the good old days of 1980s Doordarshan dramas when shows like *Yeh Jo Hai Zindagi* and *Nukkad* won over audiences with their 'simplicity'. "Yet," she says, "it is not nostalgic, it is very contemporary. It talks about relevant topics."

Director Palash Vaswani and the talented cast—Khan, Kulkarni, along with Vaibhav Raj Gupta as Annu, Harsh Mayar as Aman and Sunita Rajwar as the nosy, bubbly neighbour—all seem perfectly in tune with Singh's lyricism. "Durgesh doesn't leave us until we get the delivery of each word correctly," says Kulkarni with a laugh, adding that the cast doesn't take *Gullak's* "success for granted". Behind the camaraderie and comfort, there are rehearsals before the shoot begins and also before a scene is canned.

The biggest lure of *Gullak* is how relatable it is. Kulkarni cites how her own father, much like Santosh Mishra in this season, was suspended from his job after a dispute with the boss. The Mishras' aspiration for little things, their struggle to run the household on a fixed salary, the worry for their children's future, the free-flowing conversations over tea, are all instances one can resonate with. "The viewers have no qualms watching it anywhere, anytime and with anyone," says Khan. "*Gullak* talks about social upliftment and issues not touched upon without them being imposed on you." ■

–Suhani Singh

taught me anything about myself, it is that I like my leisure as much as I like being extremely busy. Of course, everyone likes leisure—perhaps Bengalis more than others—but when I work, I enjoy working at a non-human level. Right now, besides juggling my work in two film industries, Hindi and Bengali, I am also micromanaging production details and overseeing the script of a film I am going to direct. Fortunately, I seem to be enjoying a good streak.

Q. We have seen you in a number of OTT shows recently. Which has been the most challenging?

It was *Aranyak*. Hopefully, I will be retained for the second season, but I can't be sure because my character dies at the end of season one. It was very challenging because we were shooting knee-deep in the snow. It was minus six degrees. It is the only time in my life when I had to drink while shooting because you cannot work without constant shots of brandy. One literally cannot survive. I was also happy to see that *Mithya* on Zee5 got a lot of feedback. I wasn't there during the promotions, so I didn't expect much, but I was happy it got noticed.

Parambrata Chatterjee will next be seen in a Netflix short alongside Taapsee Pannu and the SonyLIV series Jehanabad

Q. What will we see you in next?

Well, *Kaun Pravin Tambe* just aired on Disney+ Hotstar. There is also a Netflix film by Sudhir Mishra I am in with Taapsee Pannu. That is going to be part of an anthology. Then there is another series with SonyLIV called *Jehanabad*. It's a very thrilling, rugged and rough kind of show, based on a series of true incidents that took place about 15-20 years ago. I'm also going to be directing my next Bengali film. That's going to be a sweet coming-of-age family drama which Shadow Films and I will co-produce.

Q. You have always maintained that Bengali or vernacular content should not be tagged as regional and that all of India should not be represented by Hindi alone. Now that you're appearing in so many Hindi films and shows, do you feel you are being disloyal to your *bhasha*?

If it were a binary, it would seem like a compromise, but it is not. Hindi is spoken by more people in the country, so, perhaps, it has come to be treated as a national film industry. Semantically speaking, however, it is not. I'm very much a part of the Union of India with its many diverse languages, including Hindi. You also wouldn't be asking me this question if I had done a Kannada film and that's because people subconsciously think of Hindi as a national language. I think we are demeaning and being patronising to such films by calling them language cinema. As for disloyalty, I would think I am being more loyal by doing films in both languages and by being pretty good at it. ■

–with Malini Banerjee